

There's no escaping the price hikes this year

In case you aren't in a crazy rush to upgrade your smartphone or laptop, consider yourself lucky. Because India's 2026 gadget launches are coming with an unprecedented price hike. Seriously, the price you saw yesterday may not be the price you pay today or tomorrow, it's that bad.

Nothing's Phone 4a family had some revisions after lunch, with some variants going up in price by as much as ₹9,000. Realme, Xiaomi, OnePlus and Motorola have seen price hikes of roughly ₹1,000 to ₹3,000 across popular phones. Apple's price revisions were less subtle, with the MacBook Air M5 moved from ₹1,20,900 to ₹1,49,900, and the M4 Mac mini jumped from ₹59,900 to ₹82,900. At the time of writing this, the iPhone 17's expected to see a roughly 15% price hike soon.

OEMs aren't the ones who are at fault here, as memory manufacturers are diverting yield to AI and server products, leaving conventional DRAM and NAND chips in short supply and therefore costlier than usual. And it's starting to impact even the budget products – the average smartphone prices rose 7.9% from January to May of 2026, with prices of sub-₹10,000 smartphones seeing a whopping 17.6% increase. There's no doubt any more that the memory crunch has started to bite even the budget-conscious smartphone consumers in India.

A flagship smartphone maker can absorb some inflation inside a fat margin, but a ₹10,000-₹15,000 smartphone maker doesn't have that same luxury. The choices are bad either way – increase price or retain last year's RAM and storage. Laptop makers are facing the same conundrum – all are raising prices, some are returning to 8GB configurations, or create watered down SKUs that can still fit in people's budget.

So, if you're not in a pressing need to buy a new phone or laptop right this second, should you just wait? How long before these hyper-inflated prices come down?



“So, should you wait for India's festive sales? Definitely, but don't wait for a miracle. Track the actual selling price now.”

Jayesh Shinde
Executive Editor



Let me know your thoughts on this column at:
jayesh.shinde@digit.in | @jshinde

IDC expects no meaningful PC-memory relief till at least the end of 2027. According to IDC, even as capacity expands, pricing may not return to 2025 levels soon for laptops and PCs. For smartphones, IDC expects memory stabilisation around mid-2027 but that won't bring down prices immediately, it will take a couple of quarters for that to happen.

However, be rest assured that when correction arrives, history suggests it will appear first through better configurations, restored promotions and generous channel incentives. We have watched this play out before.

After Taiwan's 1999 earthquake disrupted production, DRAM spot prices multiplied within weeks. The 2011 Thailand floods removed a large chunk of hard-drive output, pushed OEM storage costs upwards and made PC pricing reach sky high limits before factory inventories recovered. During the pandemic-era global chip shortage, manufacturers over-ordered. The cycle is brutally consistent: scarcity raises prices, high prices suppress demand, which ultimately brings prices down. What is different now is the AI boom keeping memory prices high for a longer span than previous shocks or natural disasters that caused component shortages.

So, should you wait for India's festive sales? Definitely, but don't wait for a miracle. Track the actual selling price now. During sales, judge the final payable amount. Explore last-gen flagships, business laptops, and reputable refurbished products, as they may offer better value. If your current device works, extending its life into late 2027 is a no-brainer. If it is failing, buy the right configuration during a credible promotion rather than gambling on a dramatic near-term price crash – because that isn't coming anytime soon. ■